Parvathi

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Madanapalle Institute of Technology and Science

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INDIAN COUNCIL OF SOCIAL SCIENCE RESEARCH
Research Projects Division

Format for Major and Minor Research Proposal -(2025-26)

Applicants must adhere to the word limit specified in each section. Deviation from the ICSSR research proposal format will result in the rejection of the application.

Application number **(copy from your online application)**	
Broad Research Domains as per ICSSR list (See Point No. 1.2 of the Guidelines)	**Political Science**
Priority Areas	**Women and Politics**
Title of the Research Proposal (same as in the online application)	Under the broader theme **Women and Politics**, this proposal, titled **"From Symbolic Presence to Substantive Power: A Case Study on Women Leaders in Andhra Pradesh's Governance,"** examines the growing role of women in the state's political landscape. It focuses on understanding how women enter political spaces, rise to leadership positions, and participate in key decision-making processes. The study aims to trace their journey from initial representation to the exercise of real, substantive power. By exploring their experiences across different levels of governance, it highlights how women navigate political structures and contribute meaningfully to public leadership.

1. **Abstract**
   Up to 300 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This study examines how women leaders in Andhra Pradesh transition from symbolic representation to substantive authority within local, state, and national governance. While the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments institutionalized reservations, creating a strong policy foundation for women's inclusion, gaps persist between numerical representation and actual empowerment. The research focuses on the everyday realities of women elected across different governance levels, including Panchayati Raj Institutions, urban municipalities, the State Assembly, and Parliament.

Recent state data show that women hold over 55% of Sarpanch positions, more than 52% of seats in Urban Local Bodies, 14 women MLAs in the 2024 State Assembly, and two women MPs. These figures indicate increasing presence but conceal challenges related to administrative responsibilities, gendered expectations, and hierarchical political structures.

The study spans the full governance spectrum: **Local Bodies (Sarpanches, MPTCs, ZPTCs, ward members), Urban Institutions (Municipal Councillors and Chairpersons), State Legislators, National Representatives, and Self-Help Groups (SHGs).** Using a qualitative, field-based approach with case studies, interviews, focus group discussions, and document analysis, the research examines how women build administrative competence, engage with officials, shape welfare initiatives, negotiate power, and mobilize community networks.

Ultimately, we aim to generate **evidence-based insights** that will help strengthen gender-responsive governance and support women's transition from symbolic representation to substantive, sustained leadership across Andhra Pradesh.

2. Introduction, Theoretical Framework and Scope of the Proposed Research

Up to 500 words**.**

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Through this study, we analyse the transformation of women's political participation and authority in Andhra Pradesh, highlighting a sustained shift from symbolic presence to active engagement in governance. The 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments, coupled with state gender-responsive policies, have expanded women's presence from village Panchayats to Parliament. According to the 2022–23 Gender Budget, women hold 56.97% of Sarpanch posts, 54.30% of MPTC positions, and 52.80% of ZPTC seats. Districts such as Srikakulam, Vizianagaram, Visakhapatnam, East and West Godavari, Krishna, Guntur, Prakasam, Nellore, Chittoor, Kadapa, Anantapur, and Kurnool consistently report high proportions of elected women representatives. The village and ward secretariat system mirrors this trend, with nearly half of all functionaries being women, indicating a restructuring of local administrative processes.

Parallel to this institutional expansion, Self-Help Groups (SHGs) with over 1.15 crore members provide platforms for collective action, financial access, and civic engagement, often serving as initial spaces for leadership development and pathways to electoral participation.

The 2024 Assembly elections further reflect this shift, with women elected as MLAs from multiple districts. Field accounts show that women often begin with support from male relatives or party cadres but gradually assume independent control over welfare monitoring, grievance redressal, and scheme implementation, especially with prior SHG or community leadership experience. At the national level, women MPs representing Araku, Nellore, and other constituencies link grassroots leadership with legislative outcomes.

The study uses a three-layered framework:

1. **Institutional negotiation:** How women operate within Panchayats, Municipalities, the Assembly, and Parliament while navigating caste, party networks, and patronage.
2. **Grassroots empowerment:** How SHG membership, credit access, financial literacy, and livelihood programs shape autonomy and legitimacy.
3. **Governance outcomes:** Assessing whether women's leadership improves service delivery, fund utilization, transparency, and citizen engagement.

The methodology includes 60-70 interviews, 25-30 FGDs, observation of proceedings, and document review. By following women's experiences across these layers, the study examines how representation becomes authority and how women move from symbolic presence to substantive power in shaping political, administrative, and social outcomes.

3. Review of Key Research Works for the Proposed Research

Up to 600 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Research on women's leadership in India has moved beyond counting seats to analysing how women exercise authority, negotiate decision-making, and influence governance outcomes. Andhra Pradesh, with its extensive SHG ecosystem, active Panchayati Raj institutions, and growing presence of women across elected offices, features prominently in this scholarship. Key studies cluster around five interrelated themes:

1. **Representation versus Authority:** Reservations expand political access but do not automatically confer decision-making power. Jayal (2006) notes that quotas increase numerical representation, but structural and social barriers persist. National assessments similarly highlight the gap between holding office and exercising authority (Ministry of Panchayati Raj 2023).
2. **Proxy Leadership and Transition to Autonomy:** Male relatives or party operatives often initially guide administrative work on behalf of elected women (Banerjee & Kazi; Krishnaraj). State-level evaluations in Andhra Pradesh show that institutional support, capacity-building, and community networks enable women to progressively acquire administrative control (SERP Andhra Pradesh 2022-23).
3. **Policy Priorities and Measurable Outcomes:** Women's leadership shifts governance priorities. Chattopadhyay & Duflo (2004) demonstrate that women allocate resources toward water, sanitation, and education, yielding measurable improvements. Andhra Pradesh studies similarly report substantive engagement in NREGS monitoring, social audits, housing allocation, and health initiatives.
4. **Aspirations, Role Models, and Upward Mobility:** Visible female leaders raise political aspirations among girls and young women, contributing to long-term educational outcomes and an expanded pool of future leaders (Beaman et al. 2012). SHG-led confidence-building acts as a preparatory stage for higher electoral roles.
5. **Intersectional Constraints and Institutional Support:** Caste, class, and party networks shape which women benefit from formal inclusion (Rao & Katju 2017). Targeted capacity-building interventions enhance administrative competence, yet similar support remains uneven at higher legislative levels (Ministry of Panchayati Raj 2023; SERP 2022-23).

Together, these works demonstrate: (a) institutional mechanisms such as SHG networks and training materially enable women to convert representation into authority; and (b) persistent social and political inequalities constrain upward mobility. Building on this evidence, the present study analyses how these dynamics unfold across Andhra Pradesh's governance structures.

Works Cited:

1. Chattopadhyay, R., & Duflo, E. (2004). *Women as Policy Makers: Evidence from a Randomized Policy Experiment in India.* Econometrica, 72(5), 1409-1443.
2. Jayal, N. G. (2006). *Engendering Local Democracy: The Impact of Quotas for Women in India's Panchayats.* Democratization, 13(1), 15–35.
3. Beaman, L., Duflo, E., Pande, R., & Topalova, P. (2012). *Female Leadership Raises Aspirations and Educational Attainment for Girls.* Science, 335(6068), 582-586.
4. Rao, A., & Katju, M. (2017). *Gender, Caste and Electoral Politics in Andhra Pradesh.* Journal of South Asian Development, 12(3), 323-342.
5. Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Government of India. (2023). *Status of Women in Panchayati Raj Institutions.*

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

6. SERP Andhra Pradesh. (2022–23). *Annual Report 2022-23*.

4. Identification of Research Gap

Up to 300 words

This study addresses key gaps in understanding how women in Andhra Pradesh assume leadership roles, make decisions, and navigate political structures across levels. While women are present in all 29 districts, there is limited analysis of how their opportunities, constraints, and leadership patterns differ as they transition from Panchayati Raj Institutions to municipal bodies, the State Assembly, and Parliament.

Existing research largely focuses on local governance, numerical representation, or isolated aspects of leadership. Studies highlight the role of reservations, SHG support, and training in enhancing visibility and administrative skills at the Panchayat level, yet they also reveal persistence of proxy leadership, caste/class constraints, and limited influence in decision-making. Few studies examine women's progression to higher offices, particularly in socio-economically diverse districts, including tribal areas, coastal regions, and Rayalaseema.

There is also limited understanding of how women's priorities, decision-making, and leadership styles evolve with increasing responsibilities, and how they sustain influence while negotiating institutional and party structures at higher levels. Research on SC/ST women rarely extends beyond Panchayats, leaving significant gaps regarding their roles in state and national politics, including constituencies such as Araku, Rampachodavaram, Prathipadu, and Sullurpeta.

Furthermore, the role of digital platforms, social media, and other emerging tools in supporting or challenging women leaders remains underexplored. Most studies focus on local governance, overlooking the pressures, strategies, and opportunities faced by women MLAs and MPs in contemporary political environments.

5. Objectives of the Proposed Research

Up to 200 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

In this work, we aim to develop an evidence-based understanding of how women in Andhra Pradesh move from elected positions to substantive leadership. The objectives reflect recent governance reforms and shifts in political participation.

1. **To examine** the social conditions, motivations, and institutional factors influencing women's entry into governance across levels in Andhra Pradesh, including ZPTCs, Municipal Chairpersons, Municipal Commissioners, MLAs, and MPs, with attention to reservations, SHG networks, and expanding representation.
2. **To document** the governance practices of women leaders planning, budgeting, monitoring welfare delivery, coordinating with ward and village secretariats, and working with local communities particularly in the context of expanded responsibilities after the 2020 reforms.
3. **To assess** the institutional, social, and political factors that support or limit women's functioning, including caste dynamics, party networks, bureaucratic cooperation, digital platforms, and access to capacity-building.
4. **To trace** the shift from assisted or proxy roles to independent decision-making by analysing the strategies women adopt, the confidence-building processes they rely on, and the leadership styles that help them gain authority and public recognition.
5. **To generate** policy-relevant insights that strengthen gender-responsive governance in Andhra Pradesh by identifying training needs, institutional reforms, and support mechanisms that promote substantive leadership across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban contexts.

6. Major Research Questions and, If Applicable Hypotheses

Up to 200 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

The work addresses the following questions on women's entry, participation, and leadership in Andhra Pradesh's governance:

1. What motivates women to contest local elections, and how do family, community, and political factors influence their entry?
2. How do elected women engage in governance functions such as planning, budgeting, welfare delivery, and community mobilisation?
3. What institutional, social, and cultural barriers limit their autonomy in Panchayati Raj Institutions and Urban Local Bodies?
4. Which enabling factors training, mentorship, administrative support, and community networks enhance women's confidence and authority?
5. How do women negotiate power and transition from symbolic roles to substantive leadership across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban contexts?
6. How do caste, local institutions, and political environments shape variations in leadership experiences?

Hypotheses

- H1: Women with access to training, mentorship, and administrative support display higher participation and influence in governance.
- H2: Social norms, caste relations, and political networks significantly affect women's autonomy and decision-making power.

A qualitative, field-based approach will generate in-depth insights into how women move from representation to substantive leadership across diverse governance settings in Andhra Pradesh.

7. **Proposed Methodology for the Research Work**
   Including, if applicable, justification of research sites, sampling, sample size, data collection methods, data analysis methods.
   Up to 500 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This study adopts a qualitative, field-based approach to examine how women in Andhra Pradesh move from occupying elected positions to exercising meaningful leadership across local, state, and national governance levels. The methodology is designed to capture diverse experiences across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban settings, reflecting the state's social, cultural, and administrative diversity, and addressing gaps in understanding how representation translates into authority.

Research Sites and Justification

The research will be conducted across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban areas of Andhra Pradesh. Districts with significant Scheduled Tribe and Scheduled Caste populations will be included to understand how intersecting social identities influence leadership opportunities and constraints. Rural sites will focus on Panchayati Raj Institutions, where women engage with community development issues and local administration. Semi-urban areas undergoing demographic and administrative transitions will reveal adaptive challenges faced by women in evolving local bodies. Urban sites, particularly municipal corporations, will provide insights into women's engagement with formal bureaucratic structures and politically complex environments. This selection allows meaningful comparison across settings and supports the objective of identifying context-specific leadership pathways.

Sampling and Sample Size

Purposive sampling will be employed to identify women representatives across governance tiers. The study will include Sarpanches, Ward Members, Women in Tribal Local Bodies, and Elected Representatives in Municipalities. Additional stakeholders such as Local Officials, Community Leaders, and Frontline Workers will provide supplementary perspectives. A sample of 40-50 women will be targeted, ensuring diversity in caste, political affiliation, age, education, and length of tenure. This sample size is sufficient to achieve depth, saturation, and comparison across governance contexts.

Data Collection Methods

Multiple qualitative tools will be employed to generate comprehensive and reliable data, with the process strengthened by the technical expertise of the Co-Project Director this proposal, who is a faculty member in Computer Science and Engineering :

- **In-depth Interviews:** Semi-structured interviews with women leaders will capture motivations, administrative responsibilities, constraints, decision-making practices, and interactions with officials, communities, and political actors.
- **Focus Group Discussions (FGDs):** FGDs with community members, local officials, and women's groups will assess perceptions of women's leadership, public trust, and community mobilization.
- **Observation:** Non-participant observation of Gram Sabha meetings, municipal council sessions, public hearings, and field inspections will document real-time leadership practices and interactions.
- **Document Analysis:** Official documents such as annual plans, budgets, minutes of meetings, circulars, and social audit records will be reviewed to triangulate field data and understand formal decision-making processes.

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Data Analysis

Data will be analyzed thematically. Interview and FGD transcripts will be coded to identify recurring themes related to barriers, enabling factors, strategies, and leadership outcomes. Observational notes and documentary evidence will be integrated to strengthen interpretation. Comparative analysis across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban sites will highlight variations in women's experiences. Analytical insights will be guided by frameworks on feminist institutionalism, gendered citizenship, and everyday governance to understand how women exercise agency within structural constraints.

Ethical Considerations

Informed consent will be obtained from all participants. Confidentiality and anonymity will be strictly maintained. Respectful and culturally sensitive interactions will be ensured, particularly with women from marginalized communities. The study will follow ethical guidelines for field-based social research, safeguarding participants' rights and dignity throughout the research process.

8. **Innovation/Path-Breaking Aspects of the Proposed Research**
   Up to 150 to 200 words

This study introduces several innovative elements in examining women's leadership in Andhra Pradesh. **Firstly,** it adopts a comprehensive, context-sensitive approach covering rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban local bodies, enabling comparative analysis of leadership pathways across diverse social and institutional settings.

At second, it emphasizes women's everyday governance practices rather than conventional indicators like numerical representation. Integrating in-depth interviews, FGDs, observation, and document review, the study captures decision-making strategies, official interactions, and gradual assertion of authority often overlooked in existing literature.

Thirdly, it highlights the transition from symbolic representation to substantive leadership, tracing how women build administrative knowledge, negotiation skills, and community recognition over time.

Finally, by drawing on feminist institutionalism, gendered citizenship, and everyday governance frameworks, the study offers policy-relevant findings to guide training programmes, institutional reforms, and inclusive governance strategies. The insights may also inform approaches beyond Andhra Pradesh, contributing to broader policy and research discourses on women's political leadership.

9. **Expected Output**
   Journal publication, books, edited books, policy papers, dataset etc. Include publication timelines and places of publication.
   Up to 300 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

The research is expected to generate several scholarly and policy-oriented outputs, advancing the study of women's leadership in local governance in Andhra Pradesh and contributing to broader debates on gender-responsive governance. The key anticipated outputs include:

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles:
At least two articles based on field findings will be prepared for high-impact journals in political science, gender studies, and public administration, such as Economic and Political Weekly (EPW), Journal of Development Studies, and Indian Journal of Gender Studies.

Timeline: First article within 12 months of data collection; second article within 18 months:
Comprehensive Research Report:
A detailed report presenting research design, methodology, field findings, and policy recommendations, suitable for publication with academic publishers or dissemination through research institutes.

Timeline: Completion within 24 months of starting fieldwork:
Edited Volume or Policy Brief:
An edited volume or policy brief highlighting governance challenges, best practices, and recommendations for capacity-building programmes for women leaders, disseminated through government departments, think tanks, and policy forums.

Timeline: 20–22 months:
Research Dataset:
A systematically compiled qualitative dataset, including anonymised interview transcripts, observational notes, and contextual data, prepared in line with ICSSR data-sharing guidelines, to serve as a resource for future research and policymaking.

Timeline: 18–20 months:
Conference Presentations:
Preliminary and final findings will be presented at national and international conferences on governance, development, and gender studies, ensuring scholarly visibility and engagement with policymakers.

Through these peer-reviewed articles, a detailed research report, policy briefs, a structured dataset, and conference presentations, the study aims to contribute both to academic knowledge and practical governance reforms, offering evidence-based guidance to strengthen women's meaningful participation in local decision-making across Andhra Pradesh.

10. Relevance of the Proposed Research for Policy

Up to 200 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This study is highly relevant for policymaking and governance reforms in Andhra Pradesh and across India. By examining women's leadership trajectories, decision-making practices, and everyday governance strategies, the research offers evidence-based insights into the factors that support or limit effective participation of women in Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) and Urban Local Bodies (ULBs).

The findings can guide capacity-building programmes by highlighting the forms of training, mentorship, and administrative support that most effectively strengthen women's competence, confidence, and engagement in governance. They can also inform institutional reforms aimed at creating governance processes that encourage women's involvement in planning, budgeting, welfare delivery, infrastructure management, and community mobilization.

In addition, the study's attention to social and political factors such as caste, class, and local governance culture provides a clear understanding of context-specific barriers and enabling conditions. Evidence from rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban areas will help design policies that are inclusive, gender-sensitive, and responsive to local needs.

Overall, the research provides a practical basis for enhancing women's participation and influence in local governance, supporting constitutional provisions for gender equality, and promoting more accountable, participatory, and equitable decision-making at the grassroots level.

11. Relevance of the Proposed Research for Society

Up to 200 words

This study holds significant societal relevance by shedding light on how women in Andhra Pradesh move from symbolic representation to meaningful participation and leadership in local governance. By examining everyday governance practices, decision-making processes, and community engagement, the research highlights the mechanisms through which women exercise influence, improve public service delivery, and address local developmental needs.

The findings can empower communities by demonstrating the potential of women leaders to effect change in areas such as education, health, sanitation, and infrastructure, fostering more inclusive and responsive governance. Insights into the enabling factors—such as SHG networks, mentorship, and institutional support—offer pathways for enhancing women's leadership across diverse social and cultural contexts.

Additionally, by documenting the challenges women face, including caste dynamics, political networks, and structural constraints, the study promotes greater awareness of social inequalities and encourages strategies for equitable participation. It contributes to broader societal goals of gender equality, social justice, and community empowerment, demonstrating how effective female leadership at local, state, and national levels can strengthen democratic practices, improve accountability, and inspire future generations to participate in governance.

12. Milestones for Each Quarter of the Proposed Research

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Timeline	Milestones / Activities	Deliverables
6 months	Identification of research sites and selection of participants; development of interview guides and data collection instruments; initial literature review and contextual study.	Research plan, finalised tools for fieldwork, preliminary site reports.
12 months	Fieldwork: Conducting in-depth interviews, focus group discussions, and non-participant observation across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban sites. collection of documents and records.	Complete field notes, interview transcripts, observational data, and preliminary findings summaries.
18 months	Data analysis: Thematic coding of qualitative data, cross-context comparison, validation through triangulation; preparation of draft research outputs including articles and policy briefs.	Thematically coded datasets, draft research articles, preliminary policy recommendations, and contextual analysis reports.
24 months	Completion of final data analysis; preparation of comprehensive research report; dissemination of findings through publications, policy briefs, and conference presentations; submission of final deliverables	Final research report, peer-reviewed journal articles, policy briefs, conference presentations, and structured research dataset compliant with ICSSR guidelines.

13. Budget

Total Grant expected under the scheme (In Rs.)	Rs. 21,00,000/-
Number & Names of the States your study covers (if any):	No. of States: 01 Andhra Pradesh

14. Proposed Budget of the Proposed Research, Including Justification (See Point No. 6.3 of the Guidelines)

Heads of Expenditure	Number	Months	Rate	Amount
1. Research Staff: Full time/part time/ Hired services (See Point No. 6.4 of the Guidelines)				
(a) Research Associate	1	18		
(b) Research Assistant	1	18		
(c) Field Investigator	2	12		
2. Field work				
3. Research Equipment and study material (Computer, Printer etc.)				
4. Contingency				
Total				
5. Workshop/ Seminar/Publication				

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*This will be determined by the ICSSR based on the project requirements. The allocation for publication will be retained by the ICSSR for publication of the final report if deemed to be of high quality by the experts appointed by the ICSSR				
Grand Total Affiliating Institutional Overhead Charges at 10% over and above on the awarded grant of the project, subject to a maximum limit of Rs.2, 00,000/- for major and minor projects, will be released by the ICSSR after the successful completion of the project.				

15. Budget Justification for Different Heads

1. Research Staff

The research team is essential for the successful execution of this study. A **Research Associate** will be appointed full-time to coordinate research activities, supervise fieldwork, and analyze data. A **Research Assistant** will provide support in literature review, data entry, and preliminary analysis. Two **Field Investigators** will be engaged on a contractual basis to collect primary data from districts and local governance bodies in Andhra Pradesh. Salaries are proposed in accordance with ICSSR norms, ensuring sustained engagement and quality research output over 18 months.

2. Field work

Fieldwork is a critical component, involving visits to multiple districts for interviews, focus group discussions, and case studies with women leaders in local governance. The budget covers travel, local transport, accommodation, and daily allowances for the research team and field investigators. This allocation ensures thorough and systematic data collection while adhering to ethical research standards.

3. Equipment and material

This includes procurement of computers, printers, recording devices, stationery, and data management software necessary for efficient data collection, processing, and storage. These resources also support proper documentation and analysis of research findings. The allocation is aligned with ICSSR standards to facilitate high-quality, field-based social science research.

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